



ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION
UNION PANAFRICAINE DES ETUDIANTS
الاتحاد جميع الطلاب الأفريقي
Defending students rights since 1972



PAN-AFRICANISM & AFRICAN CULTURE
WORKING GROUP



DIASPORA YOUTH CONNECT PROJECT



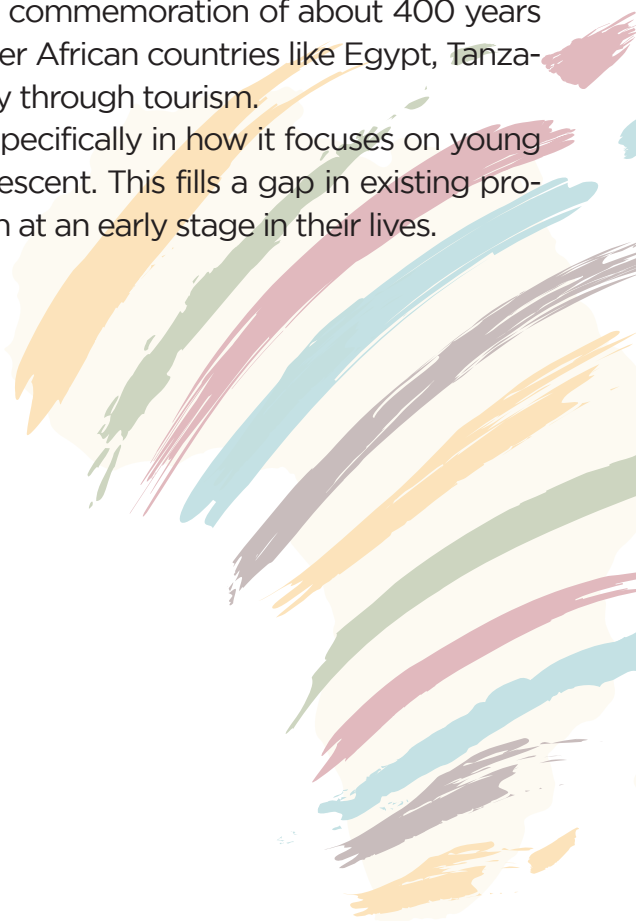


BACKGROUND

The diaspora youth connect is a program organised by the Pan-Africanism and African Culture Working group of the All-Africa Students Union to bring students and youth, regardless of their citizenship and nationality, from the diaspora. This Project is designed for young people who have little or no direct experience of their ancestors' country.

This will allow them to network and learn about history and culture, enabling them to connect with their ancestral homeland, the people, culture, and heritage. It is intended to promote a sense of belonging to the larger community in the long term, contributing to a sense of duty to the land and a desire to contribute to its growth. They will share their experiences, knowledge, and centers of interest that can be leveraged as a formidable human resource potential for sustainable development.

Recent attempts by African governments to reconnect with African descent people in the diaspora have focussed mainly on tourism and predominantly targeted financially independent adults. In 2019, the government of Ghana embarked on perhaps the largest diaspora reconnection activity in recent years. Dubbed the Year of Return, the event saw thousands of African Americans and other Africans in the diaspora throng Ghana as part of a year-long commemoration of about 400 years since the first enslaved Africans left the shores of Ghana. Other African countries like Egypt, Tanzania, Senegal, The Gambia, etc., also attract thousands annually through tourism. The Diaspora Youth Connect departs from these programs specifically in how it focuses on young people by facilitating their reconnection with their African descent. This fills a gap in existing programs that targets young people to build a strong connection at an early stage in their lives.



Objectives of the Program

- To bring students in the diaspora back to Africa to reconnect with their roots, get to know their history, and participate in cultural and other activities.
- To leverage the experiences, knowledge, and centers of interest as a formidable human resource for sustainable development.

Expected Outcome

- Participants are taken to the historical sites to gain first-hand knowledge about their ancestors.
- The participants share knowledge and ideas to contribute to their home country's economic and social development.

What it involves / main activities.

- Stakeholders Consultation and Launch of the project
- Publicity and Registration
- Series of Webinars
- Visits to historical and archaeological sites, arts, and festivals.
- Volunteering at a local community to share their experiences and knowledge.

Why the need for the program?

Modern-day nurturing has slowly drifted the youth from the knowledge and recognition of their roots, so this program aims to help young people reconnect with their cultural roots and learn more about their heritage.

Recent events like Black Lives Matter, coupled with specific national projects like Year of Return by Ghana's government, feed into the larger conversation of identity politics and the need for persons of African descent to retrace their roots and establish a more lasting connection with their ancestral homes. It is instructive to note this campaign is not new. One of the foremost early black intellectuals and organisers, the Jamaican Marcus Garvey, favoured repatriation of persons of African descent firmly back to the Continent.

Also, recently, companies like Repatriate Ghana have all worked closely as facilitators between African descent and African governments to help people resettle in Africa.

While this Project does not necessarily advocate for resettlement, it connects with some of the listed projects. It seeks to reach out to young persons of African descent and offer them an early opportunity to reconnect, learn from, interact with and contribute to Africa more profoundly than their forebears had the chance to.

How will the Project run

Students and interested young people will register through a call for registration

Who can apply?

Young people and students who have little or no direct experience of the country of their ancestors.

Monitoring and evaluation provisions

AASU has a functioning internal Monitoring and Evaluation Team led by a competent officer with significant experience managing projects in Africa. The M & M&E Team works closely with the Internal Audit Team to provide critical reviews and assessments of all AASU projects. Additionally, AASU operates under the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration of Ghana and is subject to the Government of Ghana's independent external audits.

We shall employ these tools to conduct the evaluation:

- Social Return on Investment (SROI)
- Basic Efficiency Resource Analysis (BER analysis)

Sustainability Plan

We shall leverage the maiden edition's successes to draw support from various African governments who would want to host young people of African descent in the diaspora. Additionally, in line with the vision of the African Union's Agenda 2063, we are confident that the Union could support institutionalising the African Diaspora Youth Connect project.

The project could also be integrated within existing state and universities exchange programmes.

ABOUT REQUESTING ORGANIZATION

The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) is the largest student movement in Africa and a very dominant force on the Continent and beyond. AASU organizes all students in Africa – from the basic level to Institutions of higher learning; in essence, the Union is the umbrella organization for all students of Africa.

Since its inception in 1972, AASU now has presence in 54 Countries in Africa. The Union played an important role in the struggle against colonialism and the ending of apartheid in South Africa. Today, AASU is at the forefront of the fights for equal access to quality education, quality assurance in higher education, harmonization of higher education systems – with key emphasis on the mobility of academics and comparability of qualifications, democratic governance, defending students' rights, promotion of gender and African culture, sustainable development, entrepreneurship, fostering of academic freedom, freedom of research and autonomy of higher institutions of learning, and the promotion of peace and democratic values, and other noteworthy objectives.

In the year 2000, the UN awarded AASU a certificate of merit in recognition of the Union's efforts at advancing students' rights and championing the democratization of education across the African Continent.

See: <http://www.un.org/press/en/2000/20000410.dev2241.doc.html>

The Union is wholly student-run and student-led, autonomous, representative, and operates according to democratic principles. The executives of the Union are democratically elected and representative of all the sub-regions across the Continent.

The All-Africa Students Union's key strength lies in its diversity and numerical strength (*representing tens and millions of African Students*), which it leverages as a bargaining tool to advocate for the supreme interests of students. The Union is made up of diverse students, regardless of their religion, gender, cultural background, political persuasion, ethnic origin, or social standing. The Union achieves its core mandate through:

- **Advocacy** – The Union campaigns actively in defence of students' rights, and the passage of policies on the need for the democratization of education across the Continent, with emphasis on access, equity and equality.
- **Capacity Development** – The Union facilitates education and training to build the capacities of students through conferences, seminars, training programs and educational materials to enhance the potential of graduates to access decent jobs, develop their leadership skills and significantly improve their skill sets.
- **Networking** – The Union creates the platform and environment for networking amongst members aimed at building closer relations for healthy partnerships.
- **Partnerships** – The Union constantly seeks out collaborative partnerships with like-minded organizations to work together to advance progressive agendas.

The 7 Strategic Priorities of the Union are:

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| 1. Education and Students Right | 5. Pan-Africanism and African Culture |
| 2. Gender Advocacy | 6. Migration and Mobility |
| 3. Capacity Building | 7. Democracy and Good Governance |
| 4. Environment and Climate Action | |

WHY PARTNERSHIP WITH AASU IS STRATEGIC

AASU already has the grassroots mobilizing capacity, our membership cuts across student groups on the Continent at the national and regional levels. Our alumni rise fast to hold political and business leadership positions in their various countries. As the pinnacle of students' leadership across the Continent, AASU serves as the body of energetic and intellectual young leaders of the Continent, the very reason this constituent is very strategic to drive social change and shape public opinion. As an intellectual community, our discourses and campaigns have shaped Africa's past and will undoubtedly mold the future. Our membership daily drives the agenda at national levels and shapes public opinion; therefore, it is critical that we engage to achieve our shared objectives.

Critical to our success is the fact that our membership comprises most students and young people in Africa and the diaspora. It is our vast numbers that give the Union power and strength to represent the views of students of Africa.

This accounts for why the Union is considered the first choice for consultation and partnership on issues affecting the students and young people of Africa.

RELATIONSHIP WITH AFRICAN UNION

AASU has a working relationship with the African Union Commission (AUC) Education Division. In the recent past, we have been involved as the student voice in two (2) key initiatives of the African Union in partnership with the European Union aimed at harmonizing the education ecosystem in Africa.

List of Proposed Partners

Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, Ghana
Ministry of Education, Ghana
Ministry of Youth and Sports, Ghana
Ministry of Tourism and Culture, Ghana
UNESCO
Pan-African Heritage World